



Pinning their hopes

This 1965 Viet Cong badge made of brass and enamel carries the phrase "National Liberation" (Dan Toc Giai Phong) and the red, blue, and gold Viet Cong flag. Such open allegiance became much less common once the Phoenix Program had been established.

Clandestine methods

PRUs used enhanced interrogation techniques—many of which were considered torture under the Geneva Convention governing the treatment of civilians in war—to extract information from captives. These torture methods included waterboarding, electric shocks, starvation, sodomy, and gang rape.

The PRUs used information obtained through such methods to identify other communist leaders and collaborators. In cases where suspects could not be detained, persuaded to surrender, or seek amnesty, PRUs were authorized to eliminate them by any means they deemed necessary. With little oversight of their activities and the tacit approval of those higher up in the Phoenix Program, the PRUs became de facto hit squads charged with instilling terror in the VCI.

Wrongly targeted

Many of those who were detained, tortured, or assassinated under Phoenix were noncommunist opponents of the South Vietnamese regime. Villagers sometimes falsely accused neighbors out of revenge or for other personal reasons, often incriminating whole families. Informants were also paid for their information—leading to more false accusations—while others were persuaded to make accusations in order to avoid their own torture or death. Phoenix personnel also had quotas to achieve. At one point, they were required to identify several thousand suspects every month.

Without a doubt, Phoenix helped to cripple Viet Cong Infrastructure in South Vietnam. However, it was not until after the war that the organizers of the program began to realize how effective it had been. Colby claimed that communists had found the years the program ran to be the most difficult of the entire war.